Chomp

By Carl Hiaasen

Suggested Roles:

ACTOR 1: *Raven, Narrator 2, Mickey, Director, Sickler*
ACTOR 2: *Narrator 1, Derek, Wahoo, Secretary*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

RAVEN: *(knocks on door, it is opened by Wahoo – freeze frame)*

NARRATOR 1: **(Pg 12)** [That woman] with a shining stack of red hair is Raven Stark.

RAVEN: *(with a strong accent)* I'm Derek Badger's production assistant. I brought your contract. **(Pg 14)** One thousand a day, plus location fees and animal rentals. **(Pg 15)** Where are your pythons? Derek wants a beast. *(Derek steps in)*

NARRATOR 2: **(Pg 11)** Derek Badger - the star of *Expedition Survival!* *(Derek fist pumps to the audience)*

NARRATOR 1: Every week, Derek parachutes into some gnarly wilderness teeming with fierce animals, venomous snakes and disease-carrying insects. Armed with only a Swiss army knife and a straw, he hikes, climbs, crawls, paddles or swims back to civilization.

NARRATOR 2: Along the way, he eats bugs, rodents, even worms—the grosser it looks, the happier Derek Badger is to stuff it into his cheeks. *(Derek smiles winningly at the audience, then picks a bug leg from his teeth)*

DEREK: **(Pg 31)** *(with an obviously fake Australian accent)* Take me to your alligator. Chop Chop!

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INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Are you a fan of survival-skills TV or wildlife documentaries?*
ACTOR 2: *Shows like Naked and Afraid and Steve Irwin's Crocodile Hunter have nothing on this reality TV show –*
TOGETHER: *Expedition Survival!*
ACTOR 1: *Wahoo Cray and his father Mickey, a professional animal wrangler, are hired to manage the wildlife.*
ACTOR 2: *Filming begins in Mickey's homemade swamp, where the reckless Badger ignores Mickey's warnings and ends up atop a thrashing, angry alligator.*
ACTOR 1: *When the footage turns out better than anyone expects, Badger orders filming moved to the Everglades to put the **real** back in reality TV.*
TOGETHER: *Chomp by Carl Hiaasen*

RAVEN: **(Pg 16)** *(whistles)* That's a monster, eh?

WAHOO: Twelve feet

MICKEY: **(Pg 33)** *(proudly)* Six hundred and twenty pounds. **(Pg 75)** Alice is her name.

DEREK: **(Pg 32)** She's perfect! *(to Raven)* **(Pg 38-39)** But we can't stage our biggest scene in some nitwit's backyard.

RAVEN: It looks like a real-life swamp. You'll be impressed.

DEREK: No, they'll be impressed when they see me jump that monster gator.

RAVEN: Not happening. The insurance company says no way.

DEREK: They said the same thing about the cobra dance, but I did it anyway.

NARRATOR 2: They had been shooting *Expedition Survival!* in Cambodia when Derek decided to play snake charmer with a spitting cobra that had been rented from a local handler.

NARRATOR 1: Mr. Na leaped between Derek and the dangerous reptile just as it released a jet of deadly poison. A few drops landed in Mr. Na's hair, and as a precaution he rushed off to take a shower.

NARRATOR 2: Upon returning to the set was dismayed to learn that Derek had chopped up his pet snake with a rusty machete and eaten it in the program's final scene.

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NARRATOR 1: **(Pg 43-44)** **[**The next day**]** Wahoo and his father uncoiled the python,

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Beulah and laid her out at full length. The script called for Derek to creep up and seize Beulah behind her head, instigating a fake life-or-death struggle.

DIRECTOR: *(airhorn blows)* Episode 103 – Expedition Survival! Action!

DEREK: (Pg 44-46) *(whispering dramatically into a microphone on his shirt collar as he sneaks up on Beulah)* "As if the Everglades weren't dangerous enough, in recent years this tropical river of grass has been invaded by lethal predators from another continent—Burmese pythons! They can swallow a whole deer, a panther and, yes, even a human being. Look! There she is!" *(pounces with a triumphant cry and grabs Beulah 2 feet below her head)* "I've got her! I've caught the beast! *(grunting and huffing he 'struggles' with the docile Beulah – it's like fluffing a pillow)*

DIRECTOR: Cut! Cut!

DEREK: (Pg 47) *(lurching to his feet – he slams the python to the ground and confronts Mickey)* That's the worst excuse for a python I ever saw! You call that a snake? Ha! I call it an overstuffed earthworm. (*disgusted with this scene, he moves on)* What about the gator?

WAHOO: (Pg 52) Showtime!

DIRECTOR: (Pg 44) *(airhorn blows)* Episode 103 – Expedition Survival! Action!

NARRATOR 2: (Pg 60) Wahoo and his father peeked over the cameraman's shoulder. The screen showed a view from the submerged camera. And there was Alice.

MICKEY: She won't touch him. Not on a full belly.

DEREK: (Pg 58-59) *(to crew)* No mistakes! *(he slips into the pond up to his neck - to camera)* "Soon the sun will be setting over the Everglades. I must swim across this deep, murky pond to reach dry ground. Getting across this water is absolutely crucial to my survival but I've discovered fresh signs of an extremely large alligator, and I mean HUGE, lurking close by! If that monster were to attack me right now, the only chance I'd have of escaping alive would be to fight back ferociously, desperately, and gouge it in the eyes."

WAHOO: (Pg 65) She's coming up! Don't move!

NARRATOR 2: (Pg 64) Slowly but surely, Alice was rising from the bottom of the pool.

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DEREK: *(Alice comes up underneath Derek; suddenly he is straddling her like a tipsy cowboy on a bronco)* **(Pg 66)** Wooo-hooo! *(hollering idiotically – he grabs her scales to hold on)*

RAVEN: Oh, Lord. **(Pg 68)** *(shrieking)* Shoot it! Shoot it! Shoot that thing!

DEREK: **(Pg 66)** Wooo-hooo!

NARRATOR: **(Pg 67)** Members of the Crocodilia order of reptiles don't buck like horses do when shedding an unwanted rider. Instead, they thrash and spin. Derek managed to hang on for three full revolutions before being launched airborne. *(watch Derek's arc through the air -- Splash!)*

*****later that night*****

DIRECTOR: **(Pg 71)** I brought something to show you *(holding up a disk)* The pond scene. *(puts the disk into a DVD player)*

RAVEN: Let's get this over with. *(They watch becoming more excited)*

DEREK FROM THE TAPE: **(Pg 66)** Wooo-hooo!

DIRECTOR: **(Pg 72)** Well?

DEREK: That was bloody. . . *brilliant*! *(punches the air jubilantly with both fists)* I almost died, didn't I? That vicious monster almost killed me! **(Pg 75-76)** The most extraordinary 33 seconds of footage in the history of Expedition Survival! **(Pg 86)** *(dreamily)* The rest of the show must all build up to this incredible, heart-stopping moment. We'll spare no expense!

MICKEY: **(Pg 76)** But you almost got drowned.

DEREK: Exactly! And the best part is it was real! We're hiring you to lead us into the Everglades to put finishing touches on this masterpiece!

MICKEY: *(disappointed)* **(Pg 134)** All due respect, Mr. Beaver, this ain't my first rodeo. (Pg 76) You're gonna fake the rest of it, same as you always do.

RAVEN: In our line of work, it's known as 're-creating' events for the camera.

DEREK: **(Pg 87)** No more faking it, mate. **(Pg 86)** No tame animals. This time we're going totally raw and wild. **(Pg 87)** We're putting the 'real' back in 'reality.'

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NARRATOR 1: **(Pg 89)** Mickey Cray was surprised to learn that Derek Badger didn't want any of his captive critters on location.

MICKEY: Seriously. The man almost got killed by the world's laziest alligator!

RAVEN: **(Pg 97-98)** We cannot have a repeat of what happened with your alligator. We need Derek in one piece. He's the whole franchise.

NARRATOR 2: **(Pg 103)** But Raven Stark's request to base the program in Everglades National Park had been rejected.

NARRATOR 1: [They] informed Raven that, because of the earlier egg-robbing incident at Yellowstone, Derek Badger had been blackballed from the ***entire*** federal park system.

RAVEN: *(on the phone)* For how long?

SECRETARY: Eternity.

NARRATOR 2: The crew of *Expedition Survival!* was using Sickler's Jungle Outpost and Juice Bar.

SICKLER: *(waves to audience, thumbs up)* **(Pg 95)** I just repainted the place!

(PG 40) *[a rumpled assistant begins spraying Derek's arms and legs. Derek cooperates, then closes his eyes and holds his breath as the assistant mists his face]*

WAHOO: What is that stuff?

RAVEN: Spray-on tan.

MICKEY: What a poser!

DEREK: **(Pg 52-53)** So what am I supposed to eat to survive. For the show, I mean.

RAVEN: *(applying make-up to Derek)* The script calls for bullfrogs and crawdads.

DEREK: *(dismissively)* What else? I want something truly disgusting.

RAVEN: How about maggots? **(Pg 149)** *(Off stage a piercing scream)*

NARRATOR 2: One of the catering staff was hopping frenetically and pointing at a furry, twitching intruder that lay quivering on the cake platter.

DEREK: *(strides over to the table to examine it – he grins)* Just as I suspected – a bat! *(he licks his lips)* Let's do this! Set up some lights!

DIRECTOR: **(Pg 44)** *(with little enthusiasm)* Episode 103 – Expedition Survival! **(Pg 133)** Action!

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DEREK: (Pg 155-157) *(to camera)* Deep in the Everglades, the swamp is unforgiving and food is scarce. Survival means eating whatever you can get your hands on. But by sheer luck, the violent weather has literally dropped on my platter a tasty morsel that will provide enough nutrition to get me through another brutal day in this tropical wilderness. Look! *(dangles the bat by its tail)* Unfortunately, the rain has soaked all the tinder, so I can't make a fire for cooking. That leaves me only one choice. Now, please don't try this yourself—wild bats can be vicious, and their teeth are needle sharp. Remember, I'm an experienced survivalist. I know how to handle these unpredictable rascals. . . *(he tilts his head back and dramatically begins to lower the bat into his mouth)*

NARRATOR 2: *(as Derek pantomimes)* The bat wasn't vicious. She simply didn't want to be eaten. She reacted defensively and without hesitation and chomped down on the first chompable target. *(Derek screams)* Which happened to be Derek's plump tongue.

DIRECTOR: (Pg 159) Zoom in for a close-up! Hurry! *(but Derek runs, still screaming into the swamp)*

******** days later Derek hiding in the swamp*******

DEREK: (Pg 266) *(Using his cell phone to film himself – his speech is distorted due to a swollen tongue)* My harrowing Everglades adventure is finally drawing to an end, and not a moment too soon. I'm completely out of food, out of water and dangerously weak after being attacked by a rare but deadly ***vampire*** bat. Its savage bite left me dazed and delirious, racked with fever. Why, at times I even imagined myself morphing into a real-life vampire!

NARRATOR 2: (Pg 168) It would be a humongous night for the show's TV ratings if Derek Badger failed to survive one of his survival expeditions!

RAVEN: *(to audience, almost cheerfully)* It's possible the bat had rabies. Derek could be losing his mind.

DEREK: (Pg 115) *(desperately paranoid and scared)* Time is running out. [When] the sun goes down, the predators come out – alligators, panthers, bears, pythons. **(Pg 186)** My only hope is that somebody finds me way out here before it's too late . . .

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NARRATOR 1: [*Turn in next time for the chilling conclusion of]

*(*bracketed words have been added as an transitional ending – not in the original novel)*

TOGETHER: Episode 103 – Expedition Survival!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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